

Knoppix is one of the first distributions to make Live CDs popular. A Live distro is a Linux distribution that can boot off the CD Drive, and operate through the RAM, without writing anything to the hard drive. Knoppix is Debian-based, and is still one of the most popular Live CD distros around. The biggest advantage of Live CD distros is their ability to recover data from a hard drive after an operating system crash.

Linux Mint is a distro based on Ubuntu, and has its own repositories, but also supports Ubuntu repositories. It is even simpler to use than Ubuntu, for two reasons. There are a whole bunch of customisation tools available for managing the OS, and many codecs are available out of the box, which makes Linux Mint unique as most distros do not ship with codecs to avoid lawsuits, because the codecs are proprietary. The distro is one of the few good-looking ones out there, and supports XFCE, Gnome and KDE.

Mandriva is a commercially backed OS, based on Red Hat. It is optimised for system administrators, and uses urpmi or rpmmandrake to manage dependencies. It is an rpm-based distribution. Mandriva used to be called Mandrake, and is one of the more common distributions around. Mandriva also released a commercial gaming edition.

OpenGEU is another Ubuntu-based operating system that aims to look good, building up on the user friendliness. The current version of OpenGEU is based on Ubuntu 8.04, the version based on Ubuntu 8.10 is still under development, and will be heavily outdated when it does come out. However, OpenGEU uses the capabilities of the Gnome desktop environment to its fullest extent, offering desktop widgets and a OSX-Style dock bar.

OpenSUSE is a very common and popular distro. It is based on Slackware, and there are regular updates available. There is a very active community around OpenSUSE, comparable to the community around Ubuntu. It is one of the more common rpm-based distros, and uses yum for resolving dependencies, but this is not installed by default. It is an easy distro to handle by most standards, but installing software and codecs can be more of a headache than Ubuntu for Linux novices. Both Gnome and KDE are available as a choice at installation.

PCOSLinux is a Linux distro designed to make the transition from Windows to Linux a smooth experience. PCOSLinux emulates the way Windows looks on Gnome or KDE, and is based on Mandriva.